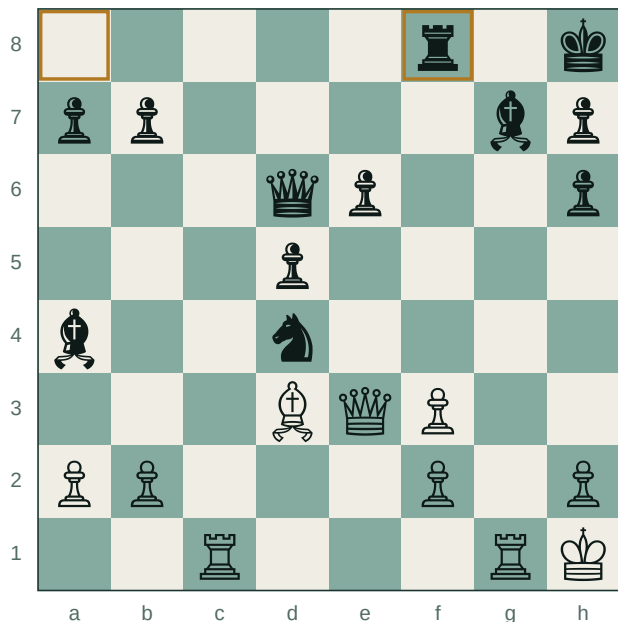


Capture the defender: White, move 22

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 21...Rf8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22. Rxg7 Kxg7 23. Qxd4+

22.Rxg7 The rook captures the bishop on g7. Recorded reply: **22...Kxg7**.

23.Qxd4+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on g7 and bishop on a4.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from -2 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: queen on d6 and bishop on a4. Check for tactical protection.